



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



ANISH PATHIYIL

become the fixture they'd never forget. Ahead of the 15th over of the first innings, Aditya received the most emotional surprise of his life. Trusha, who had momentarily slipped away, returned with a shimmering platinum ring and a banner that read: "GT or CSK? Doesn't matter! My real win is you. Will you marry me, Aditya?" That night, there was no hesitation from the only two people who mattered.

Santadeep Dey

Deja vu

Stepping into Jaipur's Sawai Mansingh Stadium offered an instant sense of déjà vu. The boundless Jan Path leading to the majestic Vidhan Sabha, the fresh foliage outside the Rambagh Palace walls, and the shimmering lights surrounding Amar Jawan Jyoti at the entrance all evoked vivid memories. This marked the Diary's third visit to the charming venue in as many years. Yet, once inside, much had changed. Though pink remained the dominant hue, striking pockets of red quickly caught the eye. After hosting Rajasthan Royals for five matches, the stadium underwent a brief transformation to serve as Punjab Kings' home venue for its final two league games.

"Bahar se gulaabi hai, par andar se poora lal hai (The exteriors are pink but the stadium is completely red on the inside)," quipped a journalist

accompanying the Diary.

While the original pink seats remained, temporary seating rows and VIP sections were draped in the home team's red.

Though the match against Delhi Capitals didn't draw a full house of jersey-clad Kings supporters, the home-like atmosphere wasn't lost. After conceding two boundaries in his first over during the PowerPlay, left-arm spinner Harpreet Brar roared back, dismissing opposition captain Faf du Plessis — spurred on by the stadium DJ blasting his Punjabi anthem 'Pagg'. The song returned in the next match against Mumbai Indians, as Brar scalped the prized wicket of Rohit Sharma.

The Kings wrapped up their run at a third home venue this season — after New Chandigarh and Dharamsala — with a win and a loss, enough to seal a top-two finish.

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Plenty to cheer about

Cricket fans in Punjab have had plenty to cheer about over the past fortnight. Punjab Kings qualified for the IPL playoffs for the first time in 11 years.

The initial leg of the playoffs was staged at the swanky Maharaja Yadavindra Singh Stadium, an open-air venue on the outskirts of Chandigarh that began hosting IPL

Roller-coaster of emotions: Love is in the air in Ahmedabad. Meanwhile Jaipur turns red (**right, above**) for the Kings.

matches in 2024. And to top it all, Shubman Gill, who hails from a village in Fazilka district near the India-Pakistan border, was named India's 37th Test captain.

"I am happy that Gill has become Test captain. He is a Punjabi *munda* (lad)," said Harman, a fan who had travelled from nearby Ludhiana, just before Qualifier 1 between PBKS and Royal Challengers Bengaluru. "I hope he leads well. I didn't expect him to be named captain. I thought (Rishabh) Pant will helm the reins."

There was equal enthusiasm for Punjab's spirited playoff run after a prolonged wait. "There was frustration watching the IPL in previous years. This time, Punjab's team combination was very good. (Shreyas) Iyer and (Ricky) Ponting seem to have a good understanding as captain and coach. The young players have done very well," another fan remarked. In the coming weeks, as Gill embarks on a demanding Test tour of England in his first assignment as captain, Punjab's cricket faithful will hope there's even more to be proud of.

Vivek Krishnan